

20 > Connecting agents to your apps and data

replies,” “ask again before sending,” or “prepare a change log before editing the sheet.”

Step 6: Test with old data

Use last month's emails, a copied spreadsheet or sample customer enquiries. Never test a new agent on live high-stakes data.

Step 7: Review logs and outputs

Check what the agent accessed, what it changed, what it assumed and what it missed. If the tool does not provide enough visibility, reduce permissions.

Step 8: Remove unused access

Connections should not live forever. Disconnect tools you no longer use. Review access monthly.

File and cloud drive connections

Cloud drives are often the first serious connection people make. A connected agent can search folders, summarise PDFs, compare documents, extract tables, create briefs and help maintain knowledge bases. This is useful for students managing notes, writers handling research, teams storing reports and businesses organising proposals.

The safest approach is to create an “AI-ready” folder. Do not connect your entire Drive or OneDrive by default. Make a folder containing only the files the agent may use. Use clear file names such as “Client-Proposal-Draft-May-2026” or “Physics-Chapter-5-Notes.” Remove old duplicates. Add a short README file explaining what the folder contains and what the agent should ignore.



For important files, ask the agent to work on copies. “Do not modify the original file” should become a standard line in your prompts. If the agent creates a summary, table or draft, save it as a new file with date and version number.

Email and calendar connections

Email is powerful but risky. Your inbox contains personal, financial, professional and sometimes legal information. Start with

narrow use cases. Ask the agent to summarise unread newsletters, group emails by topic, draft replies for review or extract action items from selected threads. Do not begin by allowing broad auto-replies.

Calendar access is also sensitive. A calendar reveals routines, locations, clients, meetings, school schedules and personal commitments. Use agents to suggest schedules, not silently rearrange your life. A safe calendar prompt says: “Find three possible slots, but do not create or move events until I approve.”

Important work may live across email, WhatsApp, Teams calls and phone conversations. The agent sees only what you connect.



Spreadsheet and database connections

Spreadsheets are where many Indian businesses actually run. Leads, invoices, stock, attendance, expenses, content calendars, society accounts and school lists often live in Excel or Google Sheets. Agents can help clean data, detect missing values, summarise trends, create charts and draft reports.

The danger is silent corruption. One wrong formula, deleted column or misclassified row can create confusion. Always work on a duplicate sheet first. Freeze headers. Use named columns. Ask the agent to explain every transformation. After analysis, request an audit: “List rows changed, formulas added, assumptions made and values that need human review.”

For databases and CRMs, permissions matter even more. Reading customer records is one thing. Updating lead status, assigning tickets or sending offers is another. Use stage-based access: read first, draft updates next, apply changes only after approval.

Messaging and collaboration apps

Slack, Teams, project boards and internal chat tools are full of useful context. They are also full of informal, messy and sometimes confidential discussions. Agents can summarise long